MODULE 1 · KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

Driving Licence & Traffic Rules

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Let's be honest, this is the module you've been waiting for. That first licence feels like a tiny plastic card that says "you're basically an adult now." Before you get there, here's everything you actually need to know, including exactly how old you have to be, how to get it done, and the rules that keep you from turning your first ride into your first challan.

1. How Old Do You Actually Need to Be?

This trips almost everyone up, so here's the real breakdown.

- 16 years old: you can get a licence for a gearless two-wheeler (moped or scooter) up to 50cc. You'll need written parental or guardian consent (Form 1A), so yes, you still need to convince a parent.
- 18 years old: this is the big one. At 18 you're eligible for a geared two-wheeler (any motorcycle or geared scooter, any engine size) and for a car (Light Motor Vehicle). No exceptions, no shortcuts, even with parental consent.
- Commercial vehicle licences have separate eligibility requirements and mandatory training

Common mix-up worth knowing: having a licence for a 50cc scooter at 16 does not mean you can hop onto your older sibling's geared bike. Gear, not just engine size, decides the category.

2. Getting Your Learner's Licence (LL)

The learner's licence is your first real step, a provisional permit that lets you practice under supervision before you're allowed to drive solo.

1. Go to the Parivahan Sewa portal (link below) and choose your state.
2. Fill the Learner's Licence form (Form 2), upload your age proof, address proof, and a passport photo. If you're 16 or 17, upload Form 1A, your parent's or guardian's signed consent.
3. Take the Learner's Licence test, a short online quiz on traffic signs and basic road rules. It's genuinely not hard if you've skimmed the rules once.
4. Pay the fee and submit. Your Learner's Licence is usually issued digitally within a few days.

Your LL is valid for 6 months. During this time, you're allowed to practice driving, but only under specific conditions (see below).

Tool Spotlight: Parivahan Sewa

Parivahan Sewa (Sarathi) is the official Government of India portal for everything driving-licence related, run by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.

- Apply for a Learner's Licence, book your driving test slot, or apply for your permanent licence, all without visiting the RTO multiple times.
- Check your application status any time using your application number and date of birth.
- Once issued, your digital licence can be stored and shown from the mParivahan or DigiLocker app, no need to carry the physical card everywhere.

Parivahan Sewa (Sarathi) · *apply for a Learner's Licence, book a test, or check your DL status*

3. The Rules While You're Still Learning

- Display a large "L" sign on the vehicle, visible from the front and back, the whole time you're on a learner's license.
- You must be accompanied by someone who holds a full, valid permanent license for that same vehicle category. Practicing solo on an LL is not allowed.
- Stick to reasonable speeds and avoid highways or heavy traffic until you've actually built confidence, not just legal permission.
- You must hold your LL for at least 30 days (and it stays valid up to 6 months) before you can apply for your permanent Driving License.

4. Getting Your Permanent License

1. Once your 30-day minimum has passed and you feel road-ready, book your driving skill test slot on Parivahan Sewa.

2. Show up at the RTO (or the designated automated test track in some cities) with your own vehicle or a driving school's, and complete the practical test.

3. Pass, and your permanent Driving License gets processed, usually issued digitally first, with the physical card following by post.

That's it. No more "L" sign, no more needing a chaperone. Just you, the road, and a very real responsibility to not mess this up.

5. The Traffic Rules Cheat Sheet

The stuff that actually keeps you (and everyone around you) alive, in the fewest words possible.

- Helmet, always, driver and pillion both, even for a two-minute ride to the corner shop.
- Seatbelt, front seat and back seat, every single time, in every vehicle.
- No phone in hand while riding or driving. Hands-free, mounted navigation is fine, scrolling is not.
- Indicators exist, use them before every turn or lane change, not as an afterthought.

- Zebra crossings are for pedestrians. Stop before the line, not on top of it.
- Never ride triple on a two-wheeler, and never let anyone hang off the side of a car.
- Never drink and drive.

Fines That Might Actually Surprise You

The Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act made these penalties a lot steeper than they used to be. States can set the exact amount at or below these central figures, so check your state's rate too.

- No helmet or no seatbelt: Rs. 1,000, plus a possible 3-month license disqualification for the helmet one.
- Driving without a valid license: Rs. 5,000.
- Using a mobile phone while driving attracts heavy penalties
- Drunk driving: Rs. 10,000 and possible jail time, even for a first offence.
- Triple riding on a two-wheeler: a separate fine on top of the helmet one, so it stacks fast.
- New in 2026: under updated amendments to India's Motor Vehicles Rules effective January 1, 2026, accumulating 5 or more traffic violations (including digital e-challans) within a single calendar year can lead to the suspension or revocation of your driving licence (DL) for 3 months or more

6. Documents to Always Carry (or Keep Digital)

- Driving License
- Vehicle Registration Certificate (RC)
- Valid insurance certificate
- PUC (Pollution Under Control) certificate

Tip: if these are saved on DigiLocker or the mParivahan app, that counts as valid proof if you're stopped. A screenshot or photo saved in your gallery does not.

A Few Myths, Busted

Myth	Fact
If I have a licence for a 50cc scooter, I can ride any two-wheeler.	Gear decides the category, not just engine size. A geared bike, even a small one, needs the 18+ licence.
A screenshot of my licence on my phone is good enough if I'm stopped.	Only documents shown through DigiLocker or mParivahan count as valid. A gallery photo doesn't.
Traffic fines don't really matter if I just pay them later.	Since 2026, racking up 5+ violations in a year, even small ones, can get your licence suspended, not just fined.

Useful Links

Parivahan Sewa (Sarathi) · *apply for a Learner's or Permanent Driving Licence, book tests, check status*

mParivahan App info · *store your digital licence, RC, and check challans on your phone*

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